

and the latest exit Manish Nagdev have chosen to walk out than raise on-screen grandkids. "I was getting film offers based on my role as a young Mihir. I didn't want to play an older man because it would have conflicted with my films," says Upadhyay. Ageing apart, there is another reason that actors are wanting out. Tired of banal storylines, television superstars like Rajeev Khandelwal, Iqbal Khan, Cezanne Khan and Upadhyay have walked out in search of exciting work. "I made a conscious decision to work for a smaller channel like Star One because the content excites me," says Iqbal, who gave up the gruelling 14-hour schedule of

Kaisa Yeh Pyar Hai and *Karam Apna Apna* for *Choona Hai Aasman*. "Even if production houses want to do something different, channels interfere. All they care about is the commercial aspect," says Khandelwal, who quit *Kahin Toh Hoga*, because, "I couldn't take doing the same thing."

But at least Khandelwal's show had a four-year run. Channels seem to want instant success, not allowing shows that are somewhat different to grow on audiences. In the last two years, at least six shows, launched with much fanfare, have been pulled off the air because of dismal TRPs. The latest to bite the dust is Zee TV's *Ardhangini*. Launched just four

months ago with grandiose sets, the show started off as a love story, graduated to a *saas-bahu* saga and ended as a thriller and will bid viewers goodbye on April 3. This isn't the first time. Smriti Irani quit Balaji's busy corridors to start her production company. But her first two shows which emphasised the opposite of the *abla nari* (weak woman), *Thodi Si Zameen Thoda Sa Aasmaan* on Star Plus and *Virruddh* on Sony, were both junked before they could complete one year. This is the same Tulsi who managed to make audiences tune in for seven years with her mix of suffering and sacrifice.

The herd mentality rules. If Star Plus announces *Kya Aap Paanchvi Paas Se Tez Hain* with a Rs 5-crore prize, Star One launches *Kisko Milega Cash* giving away Rs 5 lakh every day. If Zee TV travels back in time with a show about a shape shifter snake, an *icchadari naagin* for the uninitiated, Sahara One joins the "regressives" (as they are called in production houses) with its very own *Neeli Aankhen*. Even

DARK QUEEN: Rajashree Thakur as Saloni in *Saat Phere* on Zee TV

DAUGHTER DRONES ▶▶▶



● When *Saat Phere* on Zee TV pulled the channel out of hibernation in 2005, Star Plus launched *Bidaai*, with the same team, in November 2007.

● The ups and downs in the life of three sisters became a winning formula with Star Plus's *Kahin Toh Hoga* and Zee TV replicated it with *Kasamh Se* in 2005.

